CONNECT WEEKLY

Issue 07 · week ending Friday 23 October 2026
themapsproject.com

A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- Government has accepted all 27 recommendations of Sir David Bell's independent review into antisemitism in schools and colleges, published 21 October. Ofsted and the Independent Schools Inspectorate will get a new thematic-scrutiny role over how trusts handle discriminatory incidents, alongside new leader training.

→ **For your school:** *Worth flagging to your safeguarding and EDI leads now — 'how we handle discriminatory incidents' looks set to become an explicit watch point at trust level, not just for schools with a prior incident.*

- Susan Acland-Hood is stepping down as the DfE's permanent secretary after six years in the role; Home Office second permanent secretary Simon Ridley takes over in November.

→ **For your school:** *No direct action, but worth knowing of the change in the civil servant leading DfE's delivery of SEND reform, the Education for All Bill and the Ofsted framework review.*

- The Autumn Budget lands Wednesday 28 October — Chancellor John Healey's first since replacing Rachel Reeves. Commentators flag the mounting high-needs deficit and the 2027-28 end of the Dedicated Schools Grant accounting override as a major risk to watch for.

→ **For your school:** *Nothing to do yet, but worth blocking time just after half-term to read the schools and SEND funding detail once it's published.*

- A genuinely quiet week for SEND, behaviour/exclusions and Sheffield-specific news — nothing new and reliably dated surfaced on any of those beats this week, so we're saying so rather than padding.

→ **For your school:** *No action needed — a good week to clear any backlog from the last few weeks' heavier editions instead.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

28 Oct 2026 — Autumn school census deadline — the DfE says T Level and ILR data errors cannot be corrected after this date.

28 Oct 2026 — Autumn Budget 2026 — Chancellor John Healey's first, with SEND and high-needs funding a key watch point.

6 Nov 2026 — Deadline to notify the DfE of high needs place changes for 2027-28 funding allocations.

11 Nov 2026 — 5pm deadline for Care to Learn and 16-19 Bursary Fund claim forms, per the DfE's 30 September Update.

■ OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

▪ **Antisemitism review lands with 27 accepted recommendations — and a new Ofsted remit.** Sir David Bell's independent review, launched after Bristol Brunel Academy postponed a visit from Jewish MP Damien Egan earlier this year, reported on 21 October with 27 recommendations covering leader training and how schools respond to external campaigners. Government has accepted all of them in full. Among the changes: Ofsted and the Independent Schools Inspectorate will carry out thematic scrutiny of how academy trusts implement and oversee antisemitism policy, rather than leaving it solely to individual

school inspections. It lands only a fortnight after ASCL and NAHT's no-confidence motions in Ofsted's leadership over the report-card framework's wellbeing toll — handing Ofsted a new, specific accountability role at the same moment its general capacity and credibility are under the heaviest scrutiny in years. (Schools Week)

→ **For your school:** *Worth a line in your next safeguarding/EDI self-evaluation on how your trust (not just your school) records and responds to discriminatory incidents, since that trust-level view is now explicitly inspectable.*

NATIONAL POLICY

- **DfE's top civil servant departs as multiple reform threads stay live.** Susan Acland-Hood is stepping down as DfE permanent secretary after six years in the post; Simon Ridley, currently second permanent secretary at the Home Office, takes over in November. The handover comes mid-stream on several fronts the department is juggling at once: the Ofsted framework review ministers have asked for, the SEND reforms expected via the Education for All Bill, and Wednesday's Autumn Budget. Flag: no reporting yet on whether the change affects timelines for any of those. (Schools Week)

→ **For your school:** *No direct action for schools, but worth knowing of the change if your trust deals directly with DfE officials on live consultations.*

FUNDING

- **No new DfE Update this week — but the Autumn Budget is five days away.** There's no fresh DfE Update bulletin to report since 7 October's edition on census and high-needs deadlines (both in the diary below). The bigger story is what's coming: Chancellor John Healey delivers his first Autumn Budget on Wednesday 28 October, the first fiscal event of Andy Burnham's premiership. Budget-watchers are flagging the growing council SEND deficit and the 2027-28 end of the Dedicated Schools Grant statutory override as a major risk area, though there's no detail yet on what, if anything, the Budget will do about it. (GOV.UK)

→ **For your school:** *Hold off reacting until the Budget detail lands on the 28th — but worth reading the schools/SEND coverage that day or the morning after, given how much rides on it.*

INCLUSION, SEND & BEHAVIOUR

- **Quiet week — both beats are in a holding pattern.** Nothing new and reliably dated surfaced this week on SEND reform or on behaviour, exclusions and attendance. The Education for All Bill, confirmed at May's King's Speech, still hasn't been introduced to Parliament, and most of its reforms aren't expected before 2029. The DfE's consultation on a statutory duty to set suspended pupils' work from day one — opened in mid-October and covered last week — remains open, with no reaction piece yet from sector bodies. We're flagging the quiet week rather than padding with older material. (Schools Week)

→ **For your school:** *No action needed this week — but if you haven't already, it's worth checking your current suspension-work process against a day-one standard ahead of that consultation closing.*

SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

- **This week's safeguarding story sits under Ofsted & accountability, above.** The antisemitism review's new training and trust-scrutiny commitments are the week's main safeguarding-relevant development — see the Ofsted & accountability section above for the full detail. Beyond that, it's a quiet week: KCSIE and RSHE 2026 have been in effect since 1 September with no amendments reported, and there's no dated follow-up yet to the Bradford social-media-use trial covered in last week's edition. (Schools Week)

→ **For your school:** *No action needed — results from the Bradford trial aren't expected before next year.*

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **Quiet locally — and last week's Firth Park Academy funding decision is still unconfirmed.** Sheffield City Council's finance and performance committee was due to consider releasing £602,000 for Lift Firth Park Academy's secondary expansion at its 19 October meeting (flagged in last week's edition). We couldn't find any published outcome from that meeting in this week's searches — no council minutes or

follow-up coverage have surfaced yet. No other new Sheffield or South Yorkshire education story was reliably dated this week. (The Star)

→ **For your school:** *If you need to know the outcome, it's worth checking directly with the council rather than waiting for it to surface in press coverage.*

JARGON-BUSTER

DSG override

Short for the Dedicated Schools Grant statutory override — an accounting rule that lets councils keep SEND overspends off their main balance sheet, rather than counting as a historic deficit against their reserves. Government has already written off around £5bn of deficits built up under it, and the OBR expects another £8.6bn to accrue before the override is due to end in 2028. What happens then, with councils' SEND deficits no longer ring-fenced, is one of the biggest unresolved questions hanging over this week's Autumn Budget.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; “Who’s Losing Learning?”
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy

Source	Type	What we track
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.